

Belly Breathing

Teacher Guide • Topic 3 of 12 • Value: Responsible



At a glance	
Goal	Students use a belly breath (hand on belly, slow breath in, slow breath out, three times) to calm a busy body.
Time	15 minutes in Morning Meeting, in place of the general lesson. Centers run during the week.
When	Teach after Topic 1, Naming My Feelings, and Topic 2, Using the Calm Corner. Belly breathing is a tool students use in the calm corner.
In the bundle	Student deck (7 slides, press N for notes) • Poster (letter and 11×17) • Center kit (sort, sequence, act it out, desk strips, coloring) • Mini book • Family half-sheet
Words we use	“My belly is a balloon.” • “Hand on belly. Breathe in slow. Breathe out slow. Three times.” • “Busy body” and “calm body”

Before you teach

- Hang the poster at child height near your meeting space or the calm corner. Students point to it all week.
- Practice belly breathing when students are already calm. A skill practiced in calm moments is easier to use in hard ones.
- Say “busy body” and “calm body.” A busy body is not a bad body; it is a signal to breathe.
- Tape a desk strip at the table of any student who needs the steps close by.
- Pair students who need support with a steady turn-and-talk partner before the lesson starts.

The lesson, slide by slide

The same script is in the deck's presenter notes. Press N while presenting.

Slide	Say and do	Look for	Engagement move
1 • Title & Promise (R2)	Hand on your belly. "Our belly can be like a balloon. Breathe in slow, it gets big. Breathe out slow, it gets small." Say together: "My belly is a balloon!"	Hands on bellies; students repeat the line.	Equity stick: "Show me where your belly is."
2 • Get Calm First (R1)	Do it with them. "Smell the flower. Blow out the candle. Long and slow. Three times."	Exhale longer than inhale; shoulders drop.	LiveSchool point: "You breathed slow three times."
3 • What Did Tee Do? (R2, R3)	Point to each picture. "It was clean-up time, but Tee's drawing was not done. His breath got fast. He put his hand on his belly, breathed in slow, breathed out slow, three times. His body felt calm, and he asked, 'Can I finish later?'" Class says: "Hand on belly. Breathe in slow. Breathe out slow. Three times."	Students follow the pictures; whole class repeats the line.	Equity stick: "Which picture shows Tee's belly getting big? Point."
4 • Turn and Talk (R3, R4)	Model knee to knee. "Tee's body feels busy. Tell your partner: Tee can ____." 30 seconds, then two shares.	Partners take turns; any calm tool on the slide is right.	Equity stick: two shares.
5 • Watch Me, Then Show Me (R3, R4, R5)	A student models one belly breath with you while the class watches. Then the whole class does three together, counting on fingers.	Hands on bellies; bellies move out on the breath in; quiet, slow breath out.	LiveSchool point for the student model.
6 • My Promise Today (R2, R5)	Hand on heart. "Say it with me: I can breathe slow to calm my body." Then: "When your body feels busy, point to one."	Every student says the promise and points to one picture.	Equity stick: three names. Pointing counts.
7 • How We Leave (R1, R4, R5)	One belly breath first. "Stand up. Calm body. Walk. Ready to learn." Do not time this at K-2.	Calm bodies while moving; calm walking.	LiveSchool point for the table that walks with calm bodies the whole way.

Practice bridges for slide 5

Students model, not the teacher. The teacher narrates and asks the class what they saw.

If the model is...	Say
Excellent	"Show us again. Everyone, watch the hand on the belly move."
Partly right	"Your breath was slow. Now put your hand on your belly so you can feel it."
Silly	"Thank you. Let's see it the calm way." Call a new student. No commentary.

Centers

Print one kit per group. Laminate the mats and cards so they last. Students work in groups of 2 to 4.

Center	Set up	Read to students	Done looks like
Sort It	Sort mat (landscape page) and 8 cut picture cards.	"Look at each picture. Is it a calm body or a busy body? Put it on the side where it goes."	4 cards on Calm body, 4 on Busy body. Accept any sort a student can explain.
Put It in Order	Sequencing mat and 4 cut cards.	"Put Tee's story in order: first, next, then, last. Tell your partner the story."	Students retell: busy body, breathe in, breathe out, calm body.
Act It Out	4 role-play cards in a stack.	"Pick a card. Read it with me. Hand on belly. Breathe three times."	Each student does three belly breaths for a card.
Belly Breath Steps	Desk strips, one per student.	"Point to each step and do it."	Each student does all four steps.
Color	Coloring page and crayons.	"Color Tee. Then put your hand on your belly and breathe with him."	A colored page and three belly breaths.

Answer keys

- **Sort, Calm body:** Lee and Tee breathing on the rug • Lee reading in the calm corner • Tee resting in the calm corner • Lee breathing in the calm corner.
- **Sort, Busy body:** a friend running • Sofia screaming • Tee finds the work too hard • a friend jumping in the calm corner.
- **Put It in Order:** 1 Tee's body feels busy at clean-up time • 2 Tee breathes in, belly big • 3 Tee breathes out, belly small • 4 Tee is calm and asks to finish later.

The mini book (one child, Tier 2)

- For a child who needs extra practice calming their body: one whose breath gets fast and shoulders get tight, or who has trouble settling after transitions.
- Read it one-on-one at a calm time. Do each step together as you read it.
- Read it every day for a week. Let the child turn the pages and lead the breaths.
- On the back, the child colors a star each time they belly breathe. Celebrate every star.

When belly breathing gets tricky

Follows the Responsive Behavior Plan: the adult response is the intervention. Fewer words as escalation rises.

1. **A student breathes fast or gets dizzy.** Slow it down: “Smaller breath. Slow, slow.” Breathing should feel easy, never forced.
2. **A student lifts their shoulders, not their belly.** Have them lie down with a stuffed animal on their belly and watch it rise.
3. **A student is too upset to try.** Do not teach in the moment. Breathe slowly beside them so they can hear you. Offer the calm corner.
4. **A student refuses.** No power struggle. “You can watch me.” Breathe yourself. Try again later when they are calm.
5. **A student is unsafe.** Safety first. Use Topic 7, Gentle Hands, and the Responsive Behavior Plan.

Next in the toolkit: Topic 4, Asking for a Break.

Family connection

- Send the family half-sheet home the day you teach. It is in English, Spanish, and Haitian Creole.